

SANS SERIF RAVI SHANKAR

Parody of Politics



Disgusting, Ram Vilas Vedanti, presumably a vegetarian, turned a bloodthirsty vegetarian last week. His dish du jour—the head of Kalaiggar Karunanidhi, Dravidian politician and Tamil Nadu's chief minister. The crime: taking on Lord Ram.

Vedanti's bounty of gold that equals the weight of his current bete noire's head (considering the average weight of a human head is around 5 kg, it comes to a mere Rs 4.8 crore) succeeds in spanning a medieval divide with a few words, creating the first Hindu fatwa. For many years now, imams have been calling for heads, like auctioneers calling out numbers, of owners like Salman Rushdie and Taslima Nasreen who are seen as religiously irreverent and heretical. Not that this is the first time that someone's wanted Karunanidhi to lose his head. Tamil Nadu has a way of deifying its politicians, and Karunanidhi is possibly the only living politician in history who has had a statue erected to him. But when Madras erupted in riots after the great Tamil god and Karunanidhi's nemesis MGR died in 1987, the statue was pulled down and beheaded by rioters. Dravidian politics, which rose through the rejection of Hindu gods perceived to be Brahmin, eventually resulted in creating a parody of divinity in their politicians.

The parody of politics often acts in the theatre of religion. A few Decembers later, I was in Ayodhya when history was beheaded. Perhaps the only journalist inside the Babri Masjid when it fell, I was in the midst of the dusty melee of an invader's irreverence being purged. A sadhu in orange, with matted tresses and fiery eyes, pushed a gleaming trident into my hands and urged me to strike the dirty, old walls to avenge Ram.

Revenge is an ancient concept, that anthropologists say is linked to human evolution. Especially in tribal societies where honour is second only to God. And God's honour is the biggest code of all. But we are not living in a primitive, tribal society of fatwas, beheadings and suicide bombers. Students of Benares Hindu University don't strap explosives to their chests and walk into Café Coffee Day or Archies on Valentine's Day. We live in an India where an old man replaced revenge with renunciation, created a nation which we all cherish, whose obituary as bullets destroyed his frail chest was, "Hey Ram". More than a God, Ram is an idea. A king and not a politician. An 'adarshapurush', who set sublime principles of governance and personal conduct and destroyed the ten heads of evil. And paid a tremendous price for it. Let's not now, put a price on him.



SAURABH SINGH

SANDEEP UNNITHAN



DEFIANT: Singh

Spy and a Raw Deal

DELHI Spies don't tell once they've hung up their trenchcoats. This unwritten rule followed former Research and Analysis Wing (RAW) joint director (communications) Major-General (retired) Vinay Kumar Singh who has authored *India's External Intelligence: Secrets of RAW*. The CBI recently raided his home and the offices of Manas Publications, which published the book. Singh is charged with violating the Official Secrets Act (OSA) in his book. "They are trying to intimidate me since I am

an outsider unlike other officials who have written books," says Singh.

Former spies M.K. Dhar of the IB and B. Raman of RAW have published their books without attracting ire. Insiders believe it was the revelation of financial irregularities, dubious purchases and a senior RAW official financing his daughter's education overseas at the agency's expense, rather than secrets, that touched a raw nerve with the external intelligence agency.

by Sandeep Unnithan

The Rising Son



Singh

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

LUCKNOW It wasn't just the Congress which saw the elevation of Rahul Gandhi, MP, as AICC general secretary this week. BJP president Rajnath Singh's son Pankaj has been made president of the Bharatiya

Janata Yuva Morcha, the youth wing of BJP in Uttar Pradesh. Pankaj was earlier offered an assembly seat in Varanasi, which he had declined saying he would first like to work with the Morcha.

He mixes well with party workers and does not flaunt being a high-profile son. But the young Thakur leader will have to work hard in Uttar Pradesh to assist his father in reviving the party in the state.

by Subhash Mishra